

Understanding Autopsy & the Medical Examiner

What an autopsy is, when the county medical examiner is involved, and what it means for your family.

What is an autopsy?

An autopsy is a careful medical examination performed by a specially trained doctor called a **pathologist**. It can help answer questions about an illness or about why someone died. Your loved one is treated with care, dignity and respect at every step.

Why might an autopsy be done?

- To understand the cause of a death, when questions remain
- To learn more about an illness and how it progressed
- Because answers can bring a family peace of mind
- Because what is learned can help care for others in the future

Families may also request an autopsy. If you would like to ask about one, your care team can connect you with our service.

Hospital autopsy vs. the medical examiner

A **hospital autopsy** is one that a family or care team requests to better understand a death. A **medical examiner** autopsy is different: Michigan law requires certain deaths to be reported to the county medical examiner — for example, deaths that result from an accidental injury, or that are sudden, unexpected, or occur during a medical procedure.

When this applies, Henry Ford Health contacts the medical examiner, who decides whether an autopsy is required. If it is, we will let you know. The county medical examiner offices are:

- Wayne County Medical Examiner · **313-833-2504**
- Oakland County Medical Examiner · **248-858-4044**
- Macomb County Medical Examiner · **586-469-5214**

Will it delay the funeral or prevent a viewing?

In most cases, an autopsy does not prevent a viewing, and funeral plans can move forward. Timing can vary depending on the circumstances; your funeral home and our team will keep you informed so you can plan with confidence.

Your beliefs are welcome

If your faith or culture has traditions or wishes regarding an autopsy or the care of your loved one, please tell us. We will do all we can to honor them.

Common questions

Does an autopsy delay funeral arrangements?

In most cases, no. An autopsy usually does not significantly delay funeral plans, and it does not prevent a viewing. If timing is a concern, tell your funeral home and our team and we will keep you informed.

Do we have to pay for an autopsy?

Can we still have an open casket?

Who can authorize a hospital autopsy?